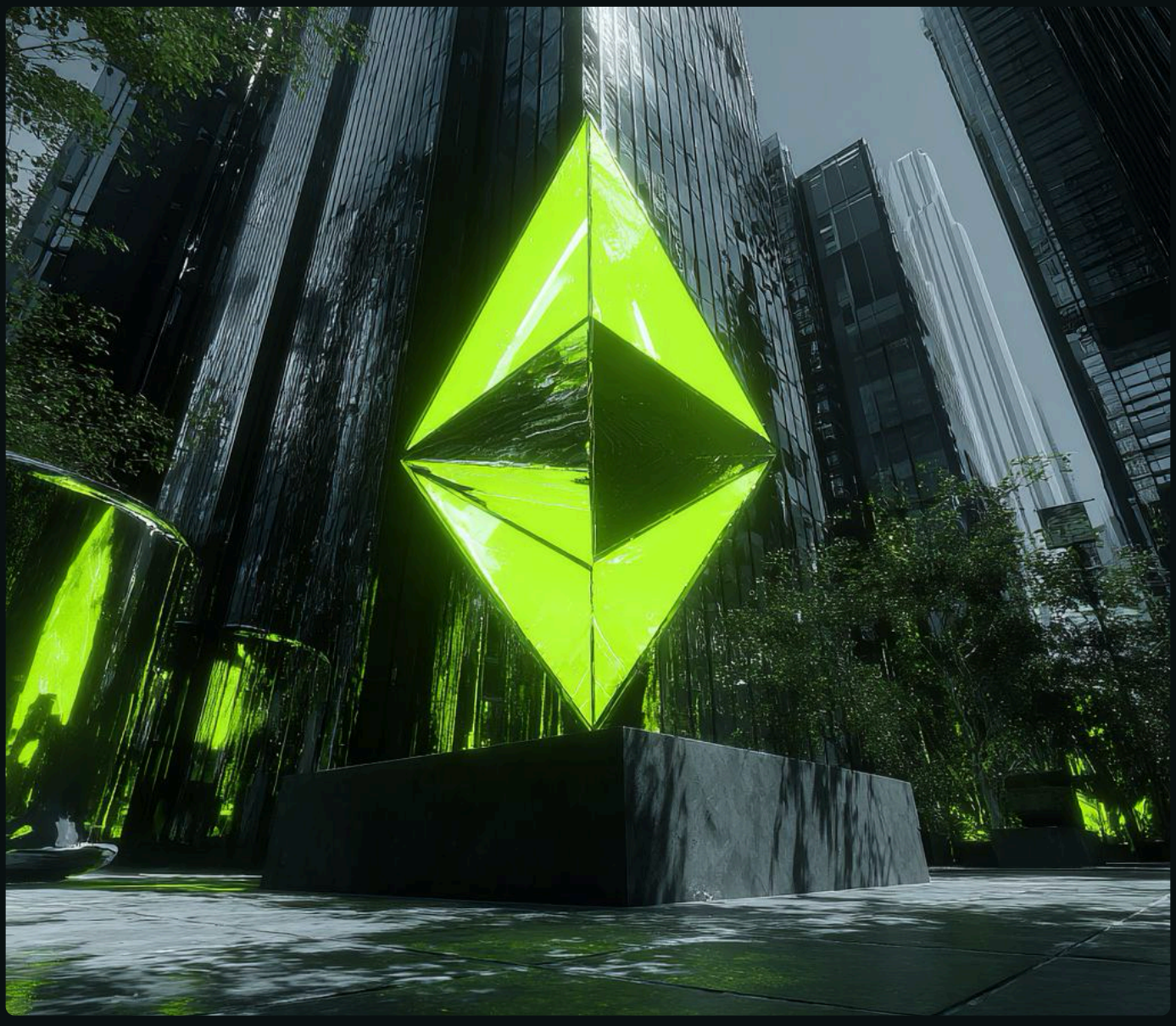
Ethereum Staking in 2025 and Beyond

Results From the Ethereum Institutional Staking Survey



The Ethereum Staking Ecosystem Is Changing

Earlier this summer, Obol conducted the Ethereum Institutional Staking Survey in collaboration with Lido Institutional and Kaiko. Aimed at the industry's leading institutions, we joined forces on this initiative to build a picture of how the top staking operators expect Ethereum's ecosystem to evolve.

We distributed it to a wide variety of major entities, including custodians, node operators, fund managers, and ETF issuers. Most of these organizations stake ETH using their own holdings or on behalf of customers, with total AUM ranging from less than $250 million up to $50 billion.

Our questions focused on a variety of staking-related topics. We asked institutions how they're staking, their top priorities when upgrading their staking infrastructure, whether they're using Distributed Validators, their involvement in staked ETH ETFs, and more. We compiled the survey with two questions in mind: **How do the top institutions think about Ethereum staking today and what are their expectations for the future?**

Ethereum Institutional Staking Survey Participants

NETHERMIND · consensys · EY Shape the future with confidence · Alluvial · LEDGER Enterprise

Bitcoin Suisse · Archetype · Chainlink · PIERTWO · kiln

DSRV · Stakely. · kraken · ParaFi Tech · anchorage digital

Maelstrom · Nascent · everstake · BLOCKDAEMON · HASHKEY CLOUD

BHDIGITAL · SevenX Ventures · Gauntlet · Steakhouse Financial · COMETH

>|< · copper.co · P2P · Figment · & More

With 70+ participants in total, the survey results revealed several key takeaways:

- **Security and regulatory concerns are the biggest priorities for institutions when it comes to staking**. Institutions typically prioritize security ahead of yield.
- **Institutions take redundancy and fault-tolerance seriously**, with most already using or testing Distributed Validators or legacy backup node infrastructure. As Ethereum grows, Distributed Validators are emerging as the staking infrastructure of choice for major players.
- **Many institutions are preparing to support staked ETH ETF products** because their clients seek yield and they expect regulatory approvals.
- **Ethereum is and will continue to be the blockchain of choice for capital allocators and institutions** because these users place a high premium on security.

Despite some anomalies, our findings were highly conclusive. One of the biggest shifts in the space over the past few months has been Ethereum entering its institutional era and our survey results prove that the ecosystem is maturing. In this new era, the staking ecosystem is also changing—with institutions leading the way. Our results offer a preview into how the future could look.

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1. Survey Participant Profiles and Background Insights

> *The scale of institutional capital flowing into Ethereum cements it as the onchain economy's finance hub. No chain offers richer soil. With Ethereum, you can simply do more; it's where DeFi grows.*



William Mougayar

AUTHOR OF THE BUSINESS BLOCKCHAIN AND
FOUNDER AT ETHEREUM MARKET RESEARCH CENTER

Although our survey participants vary in size, all of them could be described as "big players." They include some of the largest stakers in Ethereum, so their responses offer a clear view of the institutional perspective on staking today.

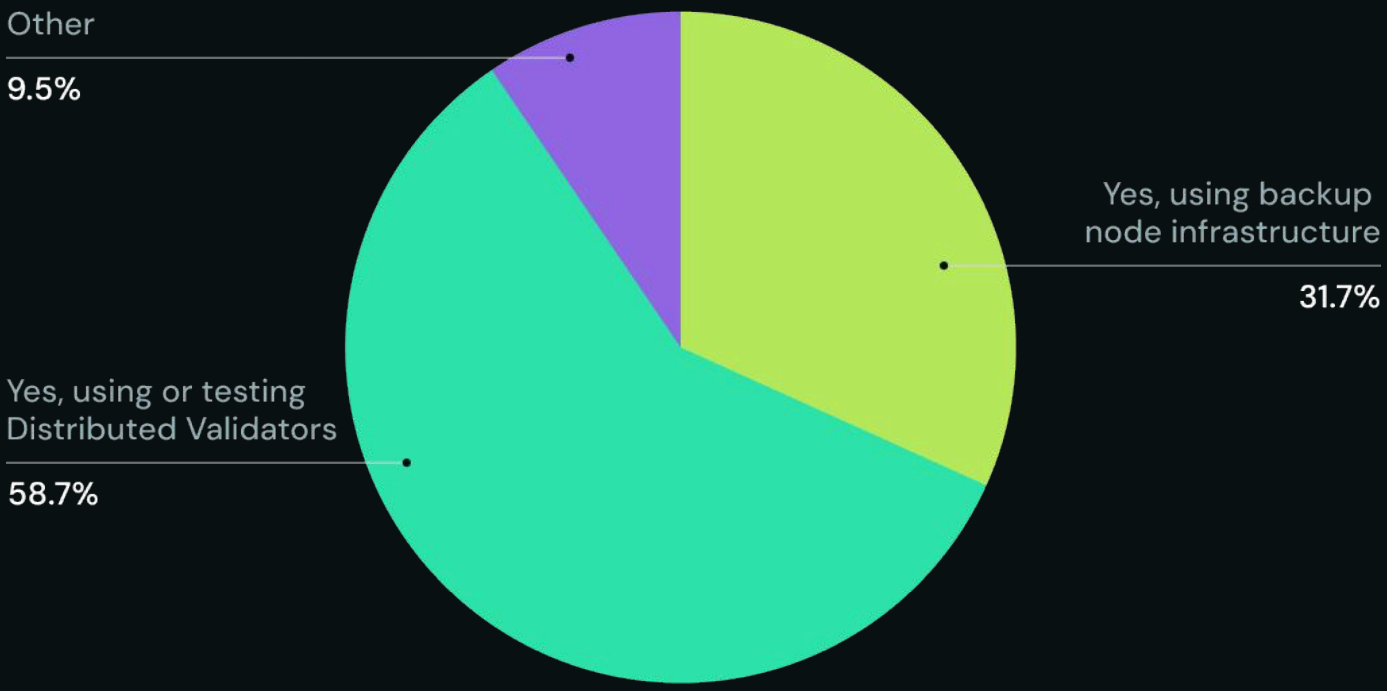
For the most part (54.2%), these entities stake their own ETH. On the other hand, just over one third of respondents (34.7%) stake on behalf of customers.

Of those who stake ETH, 61.4% operate their own validators, with the remainder using options like custodians, staking providers, and liquid staking protocols for access to staking. While staking deters many ETH holders due to perceived complexity, **the contributors to our survey are generally sophisticated actors who are adept in staking.**

~90% of institutions account for redundancy and fault tolerance in their staking setups.

Our results also show that institutions take the risks associated with staking seriously: **90.4% of them indicated that their setups account for redundancy and fault tolerance**. 58.7% of respondents said that they use (or are actively testing) Distributed Validators and 31.7% said their setups include backup nodes.

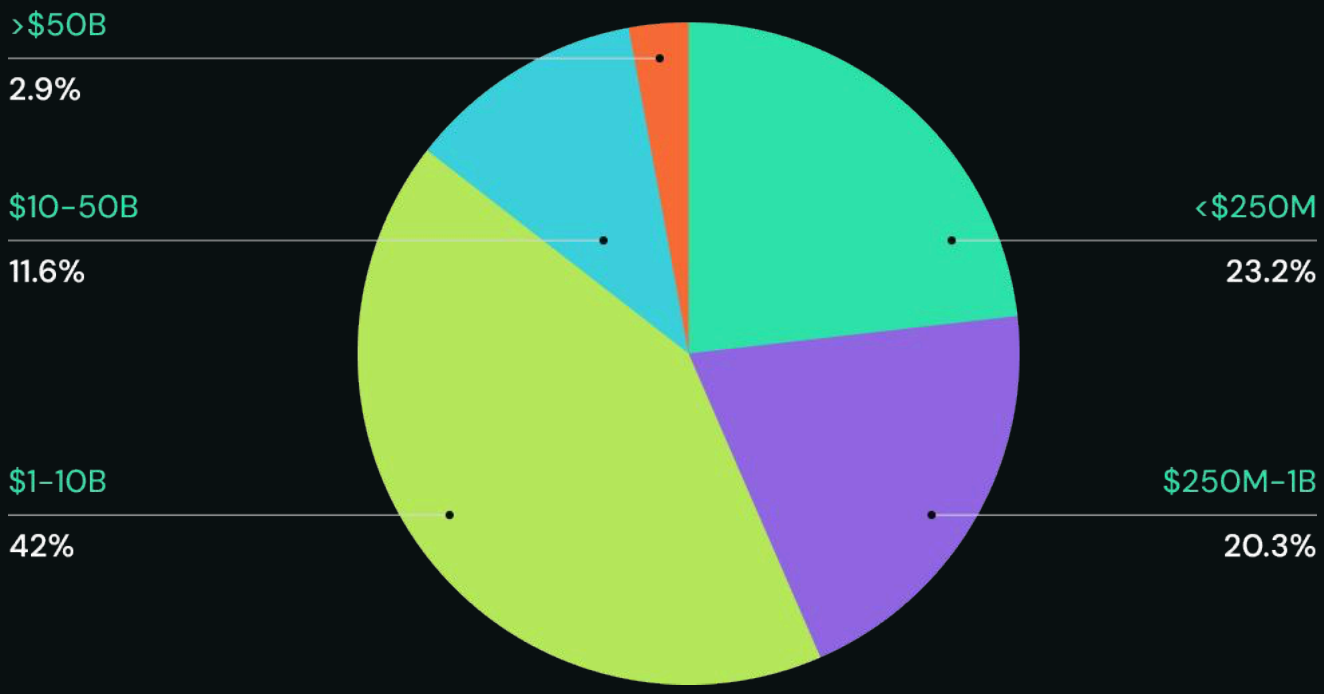
Does your current staking setup include any form of redundancy or fault tolerance?



Our results show that institutions are not just actively staking—they are operating sophisticated setups to stake the right way. We expect to see new institutional entrants to the ecosystem taking similar steps to mitigate staking risks in the future.

Moreover, our results speak to the demands of major capital allocators, with **56.5% of respondents overseeing at least $1 billion in assets**. This category of staker focuses on risk management as a priority so the strong preference for redundancy and fault tolerance is unsurprising. If we were to survey smaller entities, we would likely see a different outcome here.

What is the approximate value of digital asset your organization helps secure, manage, or custody?



In summary, the survey participants hold significant stake and this goes some way to explaining why they are adopting fault-tolerant solutions like Distributed Validators or legacy backup node infrastructure.

2. Key Priorities for Institutional Stakers

> *When institutions engage with staking, they look for the same standards they expect in other mature markets: strong security, clear transparency, and liquidity that supports scale. With those foundations now in place, staking is positioned to become a core infrastructure for portfolios, treasuries, and financial products.*



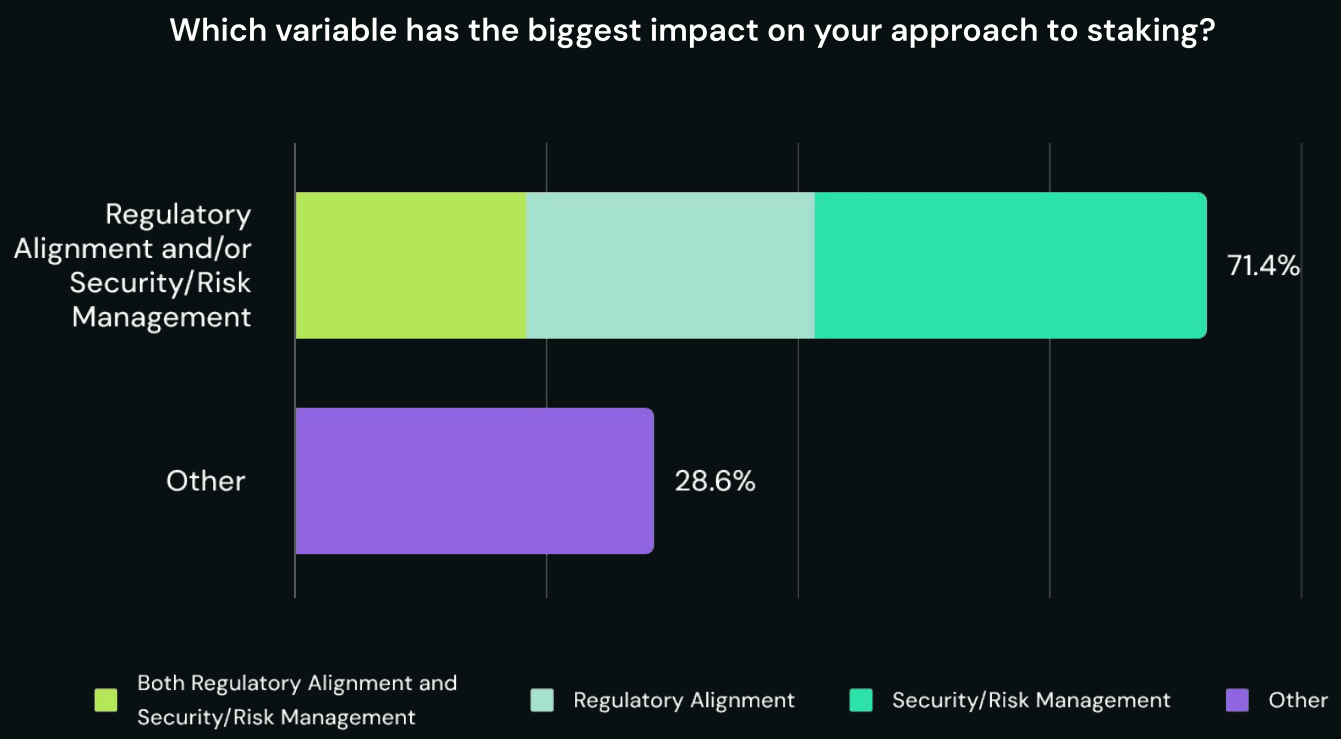
Kean Gilbert

HEAD OF INSTITUTIONAL RELATIONS AT LIDO ECOSYSTEM FOUNDATION

We asked our respondents to rank a shortlist of key variables on the degree to which they impact their approach to staking. The results were some of the most conclusive of the whole survey, with 71.4% selecting at least one of **regulatory alignment** and **security/risk management** as one of their top two variables. These answers were selected over variables like liquidity and flexibility, performance, and strategic relationships.

~70% of institutions identify regulatory alignment and security/risk management as the top variables that impact their approach to staking.

Additionally, respondents overwhelmingly selected regulatory alignment and security/risk management as their top priorities when selecting staking infrastructure. **68.1% of respondents ranked at least one of them in their top two priorities.**



Note: Respondents could select multiple answers for this question.

In short, our results show that institutional stakers have security and regulations top of mind. Although some other variables like yield and performance often come into consideration, they are generally not the top priority for institutions.

These results also support our view that Ethereum will be the institutional chain of choice for staking and the future global financial system. **If institutions continue to prioritize security, they'll choose the network with 100% uptime.**

3. Distributed Validator Adoption

> *Ethereum's institutional era has arrived. Distributed Validators are becoming the norm, and security is the top priority. As staking infrastructure matures, Ethereum is positioned to become a multi-trillion-dollar asset."*



Leo Lanza

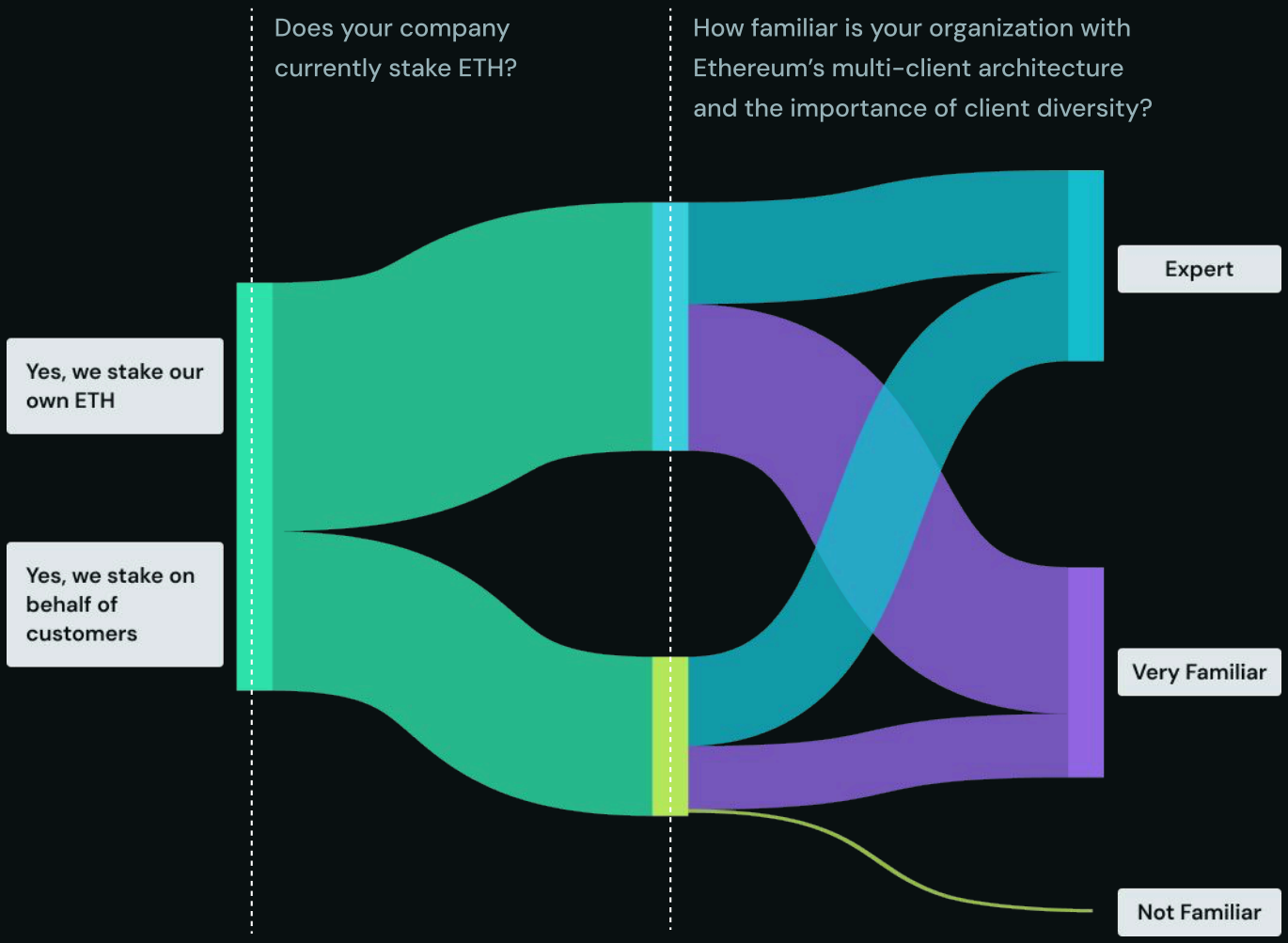
ETHEREUM ANALYST AND STRATEGIST

Our results show that a large number of institutions are already using or testing Distributed Validators. We also asked several questions to determine our respondents' understanding of Distributed Validators and Ethereum staking as a whole.

95.8% of respondents identified as "expert-level" or "very familiar" with Ethereum's client diversity. Similarly, a significant majority indicated that they were well informed about Distributed Validators. While some respondents indicated that they are unlikely to explore Distributed Validators, **we found a very strong crossover between teams that understand both client diversity and Distributed Validators and those that already use them**. This crossover makes sense given that Distributed Validators allow stakers to run their operations across multiple client implementations.

When dividing the dataset between those who stake their own ETH and those who stake on behalf of customers, there was no major difference in the responses. 96% of respondents who stake for customers identified as "expert-level" or "very familiar" in Distributed Validators, while 100% of respondents who stake their own ETH put themselves in one of the same two categories.

ETH Staking Activities vs. Client Diversity Awareness



The responses paint a positive picture on the future of Distributed Validators because they suggest that once organizations understand them, they are ready to adopt them.

> *We are seeing all of the leading staking entities turn their attention to Distributed Validators as they compete to offer the most secure and performant product to Ethereum's recent influx of institutional capital. Public Companies and Staking ETFs expect and demand the highest security, resilience, and performance from their staking providers.*



Oisín Kyne

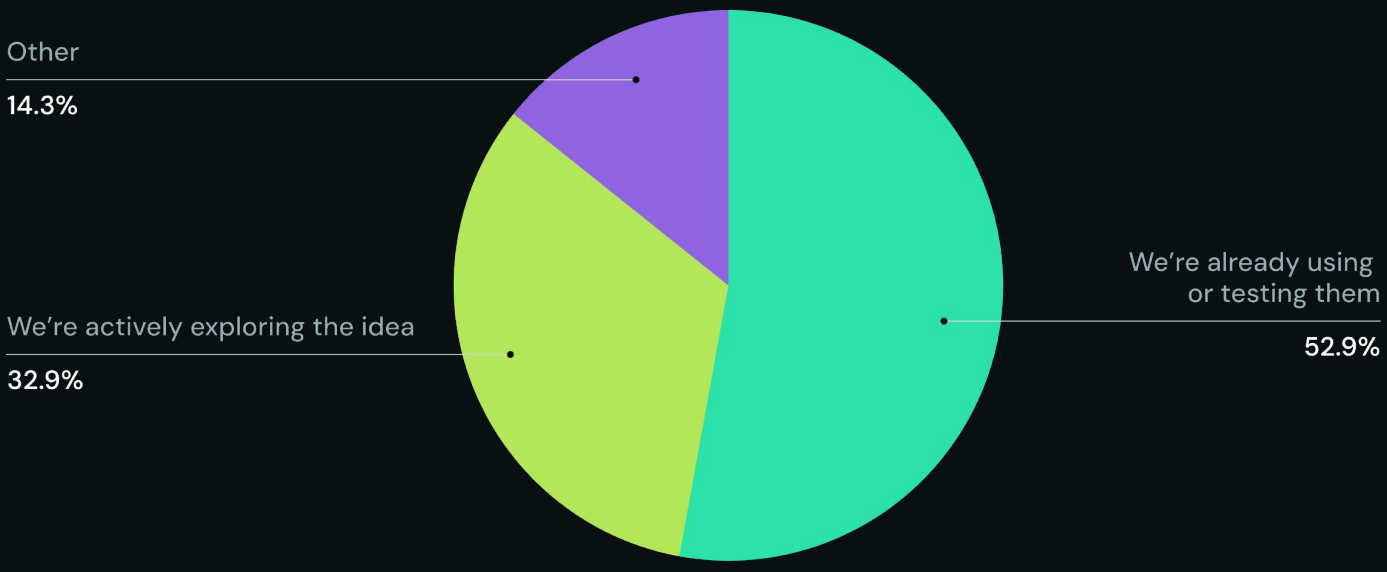
CO-FOUNDER AND CTO AT OBOL

~85% of institutions are either using or looking into Distributed Validators to secure their stake today.

Obol has long believed that Distributed Validators represent the staking end game and a large portion of staked ETH will run on Distributed Validators. We've also held the view that institutions will increasingly move their stake onto Distributed Validators over time because they prioritize security and Distributed Validators also offer performance benefits.

Based on our survey results, institutional adoption of Distributed Validators is already accelerating at a rapid pace today. **85.7% of respondents said that they are already using or testing (52.9%) or exploring using (32.9%) Distributed Validators to secure their stake in the most performant, fault-tolerant way.**

Are you considering using Distributed Validators?



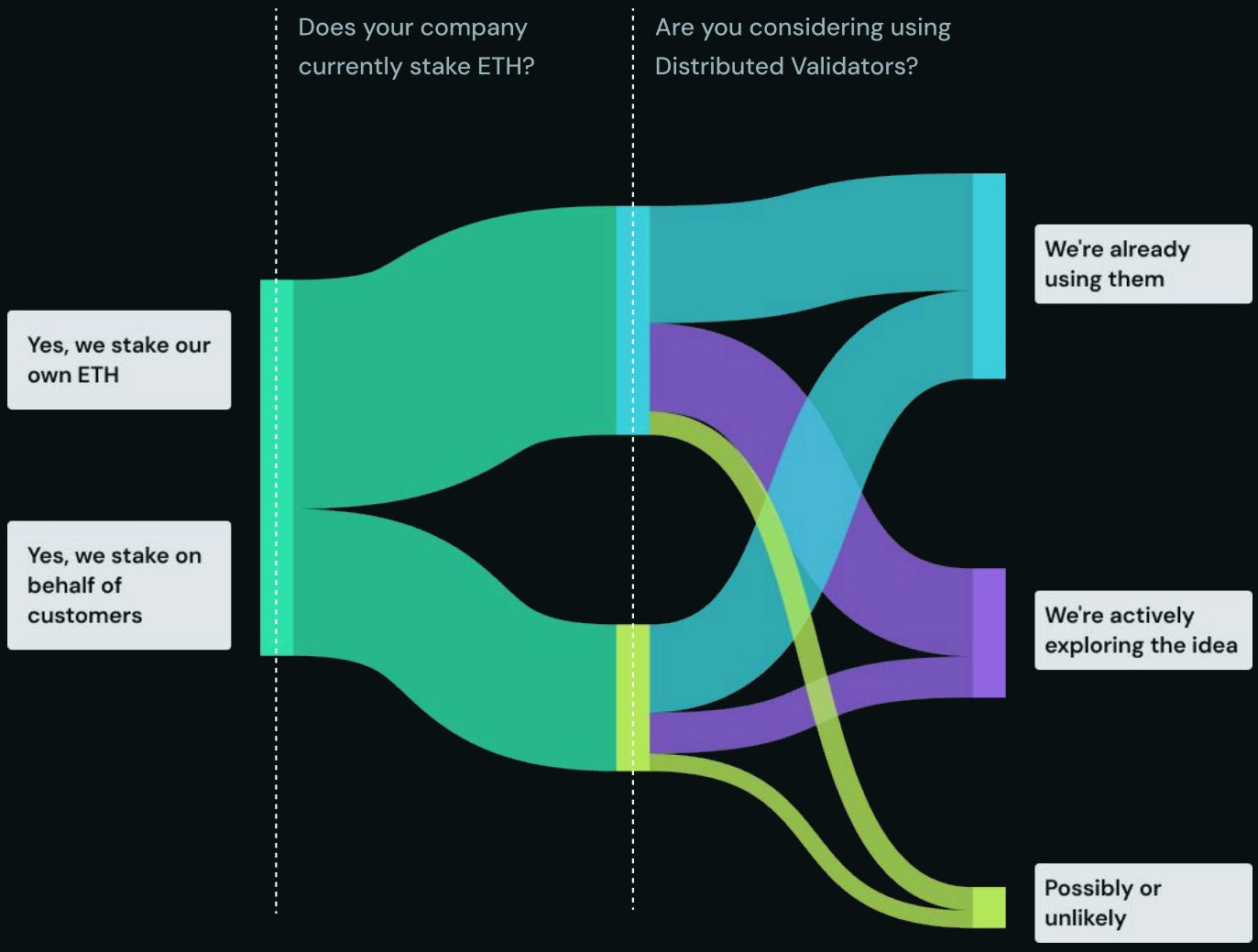
Of the participants that are using Distributed Validators today, **65.8% cite at least one of regulatory alignment or security/risk management as a top consideration in their staking operations.** By contrast, those who are not yet interested in Distributed Validators prioritize other variables like performance and economic advantages (such as yield). This suggests that the market is not yet informed on the economic benefits of using Distributed Validators (as they routinely provide higher rewards than legacy validators).

~65% of institutions using Distributed Validators highlight at least one of regulatory alignment or security/risk management as a top consideration.

Our results revealed no major difference in Distributed Validator adoption and interest between entities staking their own ETH or ETH on behalf of their customers. **In both cases, almost every entity is either using Distributed Validators or interested in using them.**

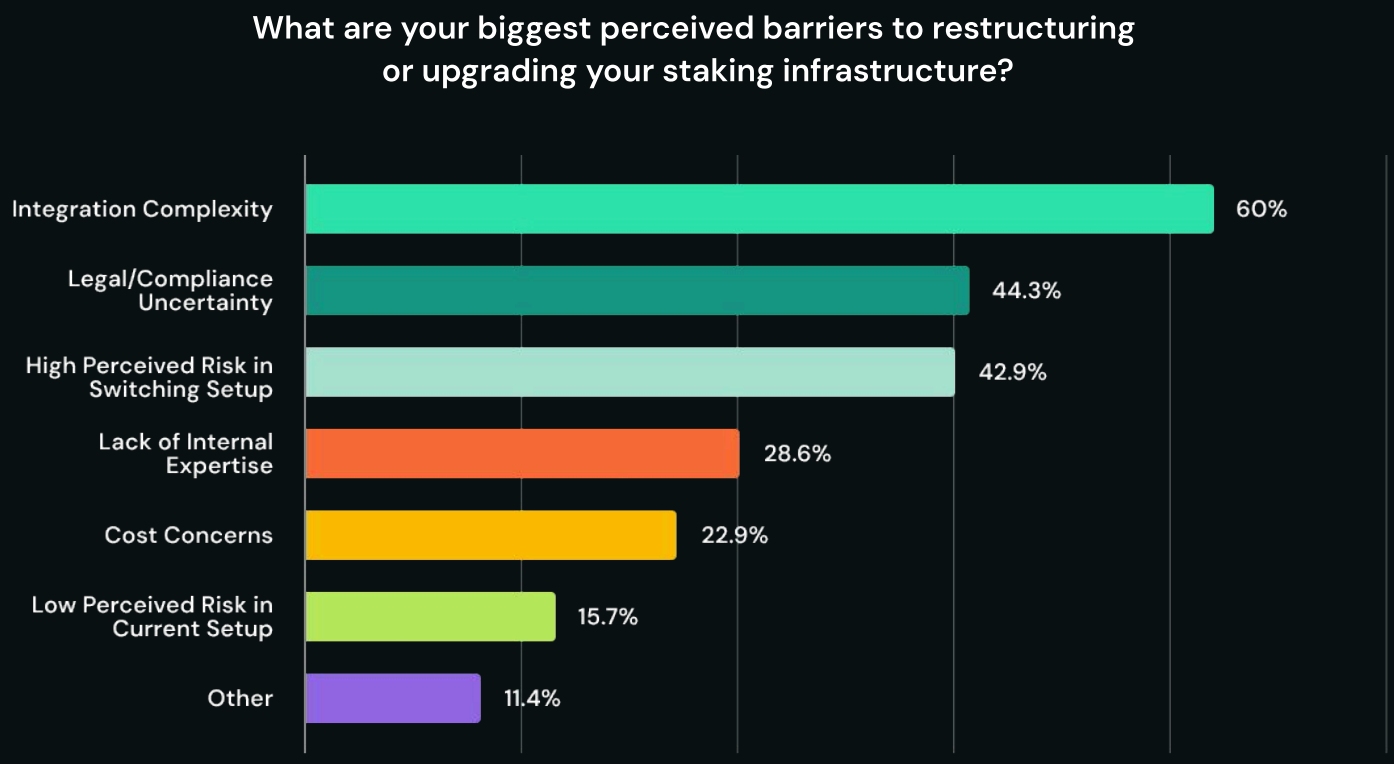
Overall, the results support our longstanding view on how Distributed Validators will impact the future of Ethereum staking. Distributed Validators represent the staking end game and this explains why a majority of institutions already looking into the technology.

ETH Staking Activities vs. Distributed Validator Interest



4. Perceived Risks of Upgrading Staking Infrastructure

After asking respondents about their likelihood of using Distributed Validators, we asked them whether they would consolidate their validators via EIP-7251. 53.5% indicated that they were likely to upgrade, reinforcing the view that our dataset mostly included advanced stakers.



Note: Respondents could select multiple answers for this question.

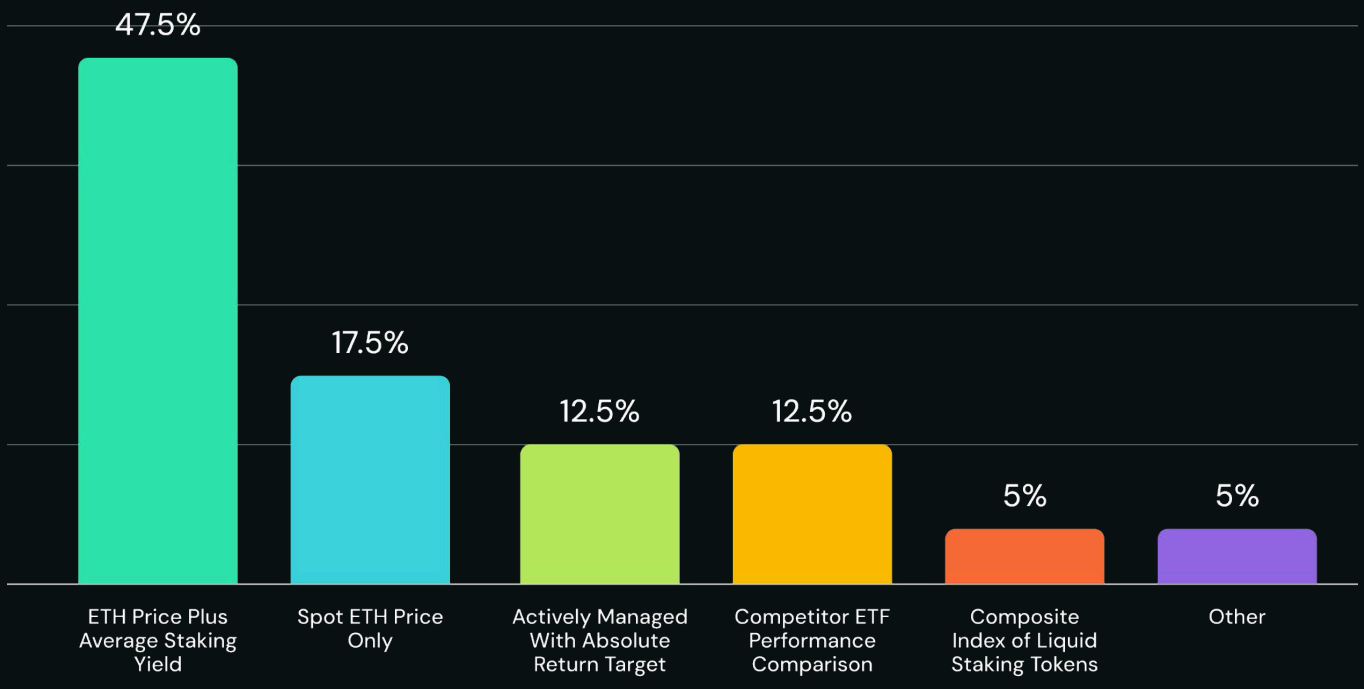
To follow up, we asked respondents to highlight the biggest blockers that would prevent them from restructuring or upgrading their infrastructure. The most popular choice was **perceived integration complexity** (60% of respondents selected it), followed by **perceived risk in switching setups** and **legal and compliance uncertainty**. 94.3% of respondents highlighted at least one of these options.

These results indicate that institutions tend to have concerns around regulations, switching complexity, and risks even in cases where they are competent stakers. This outlook is notable but will likely change over time as teams are actively working to reduce complexity and regulatory clarity is expected in the near future. We predict that upgrading to Distributed Validators in 2030 will be even easier than in 2025 and many more institutions will stake their assets once clear guidelines are established.

5. Approaches Towards Staked ETH ETFs

Staked ETH ETFs have been anticipated for years and our survey posed questions to learn how institutions are thinking about them. **56.3% said that they were actively involved in offering or supporting a staked ETH product**, with most of the remainder indicating that they were either researching the space or awaiting regulatory clarity. **Holding LSTs** and **buffers of unstaked ETH** ranked as the most popular two choices for managing liquidity requirements against staking lock-up periods, with 62.5% of those actively involved in staked ETH ETFs choosing one of the two over options like credit facilities and tiered liquidity pools.

Which benchmark would your organization consider most appropriate for a staked ETH ETF product?



Moreover, **those in the "actively involved" tier generally favored ETH price plus average staking yield as the best benchmark for a staked ETH ETF product**. Just under half of them highlighted this option over others like the spot ETH price and competitor ETFs.

As with other sections of the survey, there was no meaningful difference in the responses between those who stake their own ETH or those who stake on behalf of customers.

6. How Institutional Staking Will Benefit ETH

> *Just as Netflix reshaped media and Uber redefined mobility, Ethereum is leading the Internet finance revolution. Institutions are already aware of this. More ETH will be staked and trillions of dollars worth of assets will be tokenized on Ethereum next. If ETH captures even a fraction of global banking flows, disruption math implies a multi-trillion dollar valuation. That comfortably puts us at a five- to six-figure ETH.*



Adriano Feria

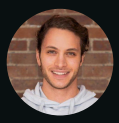
INDEPENDENT ETHEREUM RESEARCHER

Our survey specifically targeted institutions, and the results offer valuable insights into how the staking ecosystem is likely to grow with Ethereum. While this survey does not take account of solo stakers, the results unequivocally show that the top institutions are extremely proficient in Ethereum staking.

These entities are increasingly integrating or looking into cutting-edge staking infrastructure like Distributed Validators and that's largely because they place a big focus on security. In cases where institutions are holding back from adopting new infrastructure, integration complexity and regulatory concerns consistently come up as the two biggest blockers.

It is also clear that we can expect more institutions to enter the staking ecosystem in the future with the advent of staked ETH ETF products. These offerings are widely expected to launch sometime in the future, which should be a win for Ethereum. Staked ETH ETFs could potentially create centralization risk if providers concentrate their operations—Distributed Validators are a solution to this problem.

> *Ethereum is solidifying its position as the base layer for the future of global finance. Institutions look to ETH as a uniquely productive asset that offers broad exposure to that new world alongside additional upside from staking yields.*



Danny Sursock

PARTNER AT ARCHETYPE VC

Our results also underscore one of Ethereum's biggest strengths. Major players value security over other variables like speed and that bodes well for Ethereum's institutional adoption wave. Ethereum offers client diversity, which is a key reason it recently entered its second decade with 100% uptime. Large capital allocators need guaranteed uptime and that's one of the reasons Ethereum is the institutional blockchain of choice.

Based on our survey results, institutions take Ethereum staking seriously, they are ready to level up their operations with next-generation staking infrastructure, and they will continue to choose Ethereum because it's the most secure place to stake. There is an important subtext to all of these points: **Over time, advancements in institutional staking will positively impact Ethereum's underlying asset, ETH.**

Ethereum is a ~$500 billion network today with around 30% of ETH staked. In the future, we can expect to see a much larger portion of ETH staked with many more major entities entering the ecosystem, widespread adoption of next-generation staking infrastructure as that stake ends up on Distributed Validators, and new staking-focused products aimed at institutions. **Ethereum has many tailwinds that will help the network achieve a trillion-dollar valuation—institutional staking adoption could prove to be one of the strongest.**

Special thanks to Lido Institutional, Kaiko, Adriano Feria, Danny Sursock, Kean Gilbert, Leo Lanza, William Mougayar, and our 70+ survey participants for their contributions to this report.

The data included is accurate as of September 29, 2025.